But He Loves Me:
Teens' Perspectives on Unhealthy vs. Healthy Relationships

Phitsavath Nantharath, McNair Scholar Sonya S. Brady, Ph.D.

Division of Epidemiology & Community Health, University of Minnesota School of Public Health

Background

- Dating violence is a pattern of behaviors used to exert power or control over a dating partner (Centers for Disease Control (CDC), 2009).
- Dating violence includes verbal, emotional, physical, and sexual abuse (CDC, 2009).
- Approximately 25% of youth report being victimized by dating violence (Leen, 2013).
- Between 15% - 40% of youth report perpetrating violence (Leen, 2013).

Research Objectives

- Evaluate the extent to which adolescents accept or reject unhealthy dating behaviors that place them at risk for dating violence.
- Evaluate the extent to which adolescents are motivated to intervene when friends' relationships are unhealthy.
- Evaluate adolescents' perceived skills and barriers with respect to intervening.

Significance of Study

- Results may inform interventions to prevent or reduce dating violence.

Methodology

- Data was collected as part of a web-based sexual health intervention promoting condom use and other healthy decision-making.
- Youth aged 14 - 18 were recruited from 3 community clinics and 3 schools between January-October, 2011.
- 90% of teen participants were female.
- Participants were racially diverse: Caucasian (55%), African-American (13%), Asian-American (7%), Hispanic (3%), and Multi-racial (22%).
- 56 teens watched the video vignette, *But He Loves Me*, completed a brief private survey, and commented on an associated message board.

Acknowledgements

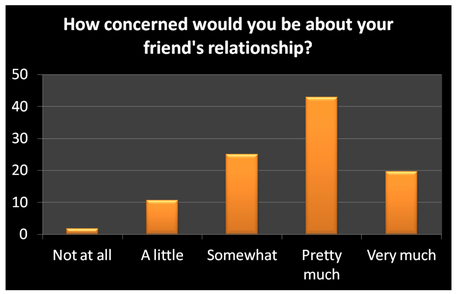
TeensTalkHealth was supported by NIMH (R34 MH086320; PI: Brady) and U of MN Grant-in-Aid.

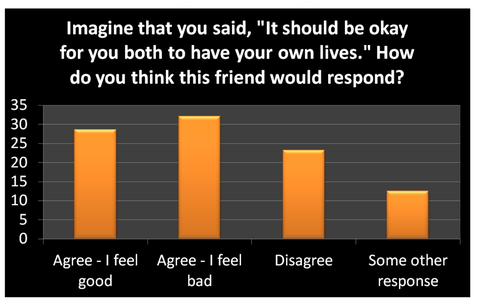
Results

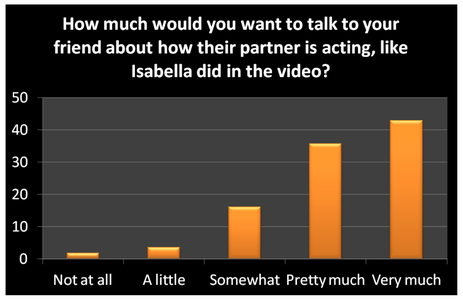
Teens' Survey Responses

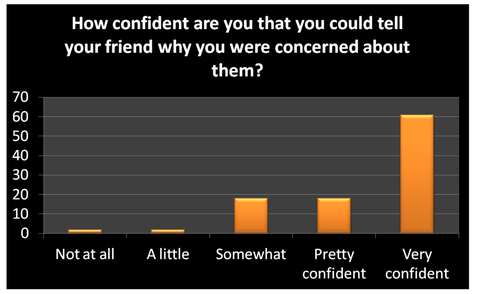
Motivation, Skills, and Barriers to Intervening ★

Imagine that your friend's partner is jealous when they spend time with others and constantly calls or texts them to see what they are doing…



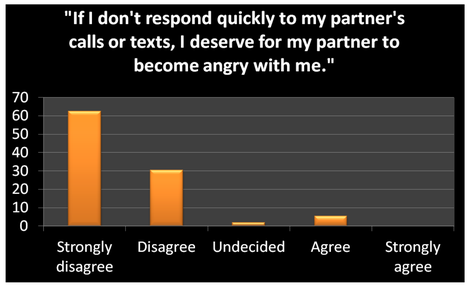


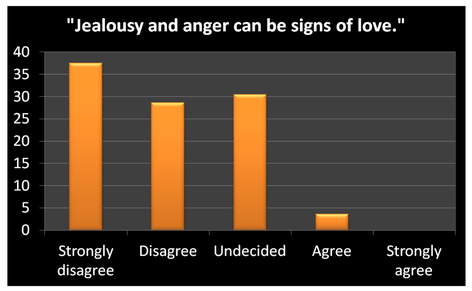


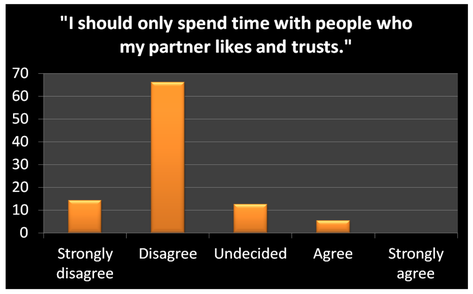


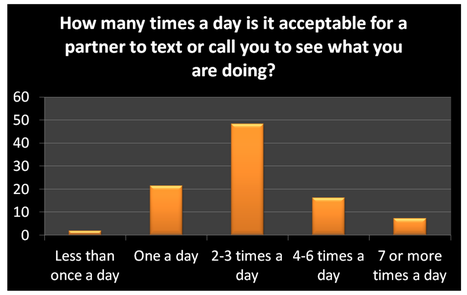
Acceptance or Rejection of Unhealthy Dating Behaviors ★

How much do you agree with the following statements?
If you are not currently in a relationship, imagine that you are in one…









★ **Percentages are shown in charts.**

Teens' Message Board Comments

Acceptance of Unhealthy Dating Behaviors

Jealousy and anger can be signs of love

- "Jealousy and anger can be a sign of love because it's a sign that you really miss the other person and feel frustrated that you can't see them. Or maybe they're just worried for you."
- "Jealousy could be a sign of love. But they might become over protective and obsessive over you."

Abuse triggered by jealousy and anger is accepted

- "I thnk jealeosy can be sexy but i had a bf who beat me when we was angry so anger aint cool, although normal, but to an extent."

Rejection of Unhealthy Dating Behaviors

Anger and control are not love

- "I don't care how "in love" a couple may seem to be. Anger and control is no way to show it. It took me six months to gather up the courage to leave my boyfriend who was just like Devan in the video. Its not love, its pain."

Develop security and trust before dating

- "I feel like im the partner who was constantly checking in on the other because of trust issues. now that we have broken up im ready to learn to live a separate life."

Discussion

- Most teens rejected unhealthy dating behaviors.
  - ♥ Many teens thought a little bit of jealousy, anger, and checking in was okay.
- Most teens were motivated to intervene if their friends were involved in an unhealthy relationship.
  - ♥ Most teens felt confident that they could intervene, but many expected a negative response from their friend.

Conclusion

- Teens should be equipped with skills to …
  - ♥ Distinguish between unhealthy and healthy relationships.
  - ♥ Help themselves and others to leave unhealthy relationships and develop skills for healthy relationships.